

# Topic 6.4 - Building a plan that survives the year

## A real classroom situation

In September, Miss Hina writes a professional development plan because her school asks for one.

It has six goals. It says she will improve her questioning, integrate technology, develop better assessment practices, build stronger parent relationships, read more widely in her subject, and attend a conference.

By March she has done none of it, and she feels vaguely guilty about a document she has not reopened since September.

Nothing is wrong with Miss Hina. The plan was defeated before it began, and the specific reasons are predictable enough to design against.

## Explanation

### What a personal professional development plan contains

A professional development plan is a short written statement of what you intend to get better at, how, and how you will know. One page is the right length. Six blocks, shown in the figure above.

**The gap, stated specifically.** Not "questioning" but "in Class 7, the same four pupils answer every question and I do not know what the other thirty-four understand". Unit 4's indicator discipline applies: a gap you cannot observe is a gap you cannot close.

**The evidence that the gap is real.** Not a feeling. A tally, a set of pupil work, a colleague's observation. This block is what stops a plan being a list of virtues.

**One goal.** One. This is the block Miss Hina's plan violated six times over, and it is the single most common reason plans fail. A teacher with one goal in a year is unusually ambitious.

**The activity.** What you will actually do: a lesson study cycle with two colleagues, a term of structured trials, a specific reading, a fortnightly conversation. Chosen from Topic 6.3 against what that route can actually deliver.

**The evidence that would show change.** Decided now, in September, not in March. Unit 3's researcher discipline and Unit 4's self-evaluation cycle are the same rule arriving for the third time, which is deliberate: it is the rule most often skipped and the one that makes the difference between a plan and an intention.

**The review date.** A date, in the diary, in the middle of the year, at which you reopen the plan and decide whether it survived.

**One more thing that belongs on the page and is usually missing:** what you will stop doing, or who will help. A goal with no room made for it competes with a full working week and loses.

## Making a plan that survives a school year

Four things destroy a plan, and each has a design response.

**Too many goals.** Miss Hina's six. The response is the one-goal rule, and it is harder than it sounds because writing one goal means explicitly not addressing five things you know are weak. That discomfort is the plan working.

**No time was made.** A goal added to a full week is a goal that loses to the week. The response is the block above: name what you will stop doing, or who is helping, or when the hour comes from. Unit 5's demands-and-resources framing is exactly this: you are adding a demand, so you must add a resource or remove another demand.

**No evidence was decided in advance.** Then in March there is nothing to look at, and the honest answer to "did it work" is that you cannot tell. The response

is the fifth block.

**No review date.** A plan nobody reopens is a document, not a plan. The response is a date in the diary in the middle of the year, not at the end, because the end is too late to act on.

The figure above adds the part most plans omit entirely: **what happens at the review**. Three outcomes are legitimate.

**Continue unchanged**, because it is working and not finished.

**Narrow the goal**, because it turned out to be bigger than a year. This is the commonest and it is a success, not a retreat.

**Replace it**, because the evidence showed the real gap was somewhere else. Also a success: you have learned something true about your own practice, which was the point.

What is not legitimate is quiet abandonment, and the review date exists to make abandonment a decision rather than a drift.

A misconception to name, because it determines whether any of this is worth doing: **a development plan is a document you write for an appraiser**. If that is what it is, it will be written to look good and it will be useless, for exactly the reasons Unit 4 gave about mixing development with judgement. The plan described here is **yours**. Where a school requires a copy, a summary can be provided; the working document, with its honest statement of a gap, does not have to be the same piece of paper.

## **Closing: what this course was for**

This is the end of the course, and it is worth naming what has been built.

Unit 1 argued that teaching is a profession because it rests on specialised knowledge, a code, and accountability. Unit 2 gave the ethical obligations and two models for deciding when they conflict. Unit 3 described what effective teaching consists of and the roles a teacher now plays. Unit 4 gave the written standards and how to use one on yourself. Unit 5 described the conditions honestly and ended on what remains in your control.

Each of those ends in the same place. A profession's claim rests on its members continuing to develop; the ethical obligation to teach competently implies keeping competent; effectiveness components are not fixed; standards are used for self-evaluation; and conditions are hard, which makes the question of what is within your control urgent rather than academic.

The one-page plan is where all five become a single action. If you take one thing from this course, take the page.

## Activity: Build the page

Work individually for twenty minutes, then in pairs.

Write your own plan, all six blocks, on one page. Use a real gap from your practicum or from your own schooling if you have not yet taught.

Then exchange with a partner, whose job is to attack it on four questions only:

**Is the gap specific enough to observe? Is there really only one goal? Where does the time come from? Could you tell in March whether it worked?**

Revise. Allow 35 minutes in total, and keep the page: it is the deliverable of this unit and, arguably, of the course.

## Check your understanding

1. Name the six blocks of a one-page development plan. *(Remember)*
2. Explain why "improve my questioning" fails as a gap statement and rewrite it so it does not. *(Apply)*
3. Give the four things that destroy a plan, with the design response to each. *(Remember)*
4. Explain why narrowing a goal at the mid-year review is a success rather than a retreat. *(Understand)*
5. Explain why a plan written for an appraiser will be useless, referring to the separation of development from judgement. *(Analyze)*

6. Why is the review date set in the middle of the year rather than at the end?  
(Understand)

## Summary

A personal development plan is one page with six blocks: the gap stated specifically, the evidence that it is real, one goal, the activity, the evidence that would show change, and a review date. A seventh element is usually missing and matters: what you will stop doing, or who is helping, or where the time comes from.

Four things destroy a plan: too many goals, no time made for it, no evidence decided in advance, and no review date. Each has a design response, and the one-goal rule is the hardest because it means explicitly not addressing weaknesses you know about.

At the mid-year review three outcomes are legitimate: continue, narrow the goal, or replace it because the real gap was elsewhere. Narrowing is the commonest and is a success. Quiet abandonment is what the review date exists to prevent.

A plan written for an appraiser will be written to look good and will be useless. The working document is yours.

## Self-assessment checklist

Sign in to sync your ticks across devices.

- ☐ I can name the six blocks and explain what each prevents.
- ☐ I can state a gap specifically enough to observe it.
- ☐ I can hold myself to one goal.
- ☐ I can say where the time for my goal comes from.
- ☐ I can decide in advance what evidence would show change.
- ☐ I can treat a mid-year narrowing as a success rather than a failure.

# Try this at your practicum school

Ask your mentor teacher whether they have a professional development plan, and if so, whether they have reopened it since writing it.

Then ask a different question: "What are you trying to get better at this year?" Many teachers without a plan have a clear answer to the second question, and many with a plan do not.

Write half a page on what that tells you about the relationship between the document and the intention.

## Summative task

Write 450 to 500 words.

Submit your own one-page plan, and defend it.

Include the plan itself, then justify each block: why this gap, what evidence establishes it, why one goal and not another, why this activity given what Topic 6.3 says it can deliver, what evidence you will collect and why it would be capable of showing you were wrong, and where the time comes from. Finish by naming which of the four destroyers your plan is most vulnerable to and what you have done about it.

### Mini-rubric

| Criterion                       | What a strong response does                                                           |
|---------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Specificity of the gap (Apply)  | Stated so that an observer could confirm or disconfirm it                             |
| Fit of the activity             | Chosen against what that route can actually deliver, per Topic 6.3, not by preference |
| <b>Evidence design (Create)</b> | <b>Decided in advance and genuinely capable of showing the goal was not met</b>       |

| Criterion                    | What a strong response does                                                                                              |
|------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Self-diagnosis<br>(Evaluate) | <b>Names the plan's own weakest point honestly and addresses it, rather than presenting a plan with no vulnerability</b> |

## Further reading

- Guskey, T. R. (2000). *Evaluating professional development*. Corwin Press.
- Day, C. (1999). *Developing teachers: The challenges of lifelong learning*. Falmer Press.
- Brookfield, S. D. (2017). *Becoming a critically reflective teacher* (2nd ed.). Jossey-Bass.

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